

Beginnings of political philosophy



The Pnyx, a hill in Athens where in the sixth century BCE Athenians held the popular assemblies that evolved into the world's first democratic system.

Perhaps because Athens had established a form of democracy that demanded the active participation of its citizens (or at least, a certain class of its citizens), Athenian philosophers soon began to apply the ideas of moral philosophy to society as a whole. Concepts of virtue, such as justice and freedom, were seen to relate not only to the individual, but also to the *polis*, the city-state.

This new field of ethics thus became known as politics – ‘things to do with the *polis*’ – or political philosophy. Like the broader study of moral philosophy, its main concern for Greek philosophers was in defining the virtues appropriate to the state, but also included the idea of *eudaimonia*: how should an entire society be organized to best allow its citizens to live a ‘good life’? By extension, this involved an examination of the various ways in which a state could be governed, the means by which its laws could be made and enforced, and the relationship between the individual and the state.